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Penelope Brown and Stephen C. Levinson

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Studies in Interactional Sociolinguistics 4

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Politeness

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Politeness

Some universals in language usage

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To the memory of Erving Goffman

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*	ungrammatical
r	rude
p	polite
c.i.	conversationally implicates
FTA	face-threatening act
S	speaker
H	hearer, addressee
P	power
D	social distance
R_x	rating of imposition
W_x	seriousness (weightiness) of FTA <i>x</i>
C	context
MP	Model Person
T	second-person singular pronoun ('tu')
V	second-person plural honorific pronoun ('vous')
⊢	1. entailment 2. assertion sign
⊃	if-then (material conditional)
iff	if and only if
ø	as 'a' in hall
/	stress

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[More information](#)**FOREWORD** · *John J. Gumperz*

The bulk of the material in this volume first appeared in a collection in the series Cambridge Papers in Social Anthropology, volume 8. Its reissue will now make it available to a much wider audience. In the years since it first appeared it has come to be accepted as the classic treatment on politeness in communication. As an integrative treatment of phenomena previously dealt with in a variety of disciplines it is now widely cited by linguists, psychologists and students of social interaction. A major reason for this interest is that politeness, as the authors define it, is basic to the production of social order, and a precondition of human cooperation, so that any theory which provides an understanding of this phenomenon at the same time goes to the foundations of human social life.

In addition to their status as universal principles of human interaction, politeness phenomena by their very nature are reflected in language. Societies everywhere, no matter what their degree of isolation or their socioeconomic complexity, show these same principles at work; yet what counts as polite may differ from group to group, from situation to situation, or from individual to individual. If we can find some underlying grammatical and social regularities which account both for this type of variation and for the recurrent patterns, we will have taken a major step in demonstrating and not just claiming the basically social nature of human language. One of the reasons for the attention that this work has created, is the fact that an abstract theoretical framework has been proposed which does indeed account for the bulk of the cross-linguistic and cross-cultural data, and which also yields predictions which can be (and in some cases have been) tested through independent experiments.

Apart from its general import, the book makes a number of important theoretical and methodological points relevant to current interests in both linguistics and sociolinguistics. Politeness principles are reflected in linguistic universals which are in many ways equivalent to those discovered by grammarians. However, the methods by which these universals are derived constitute a significant departure from current practice. Grammarians rely on informants' responses to systematic elicitation procedures to deduce abstract rules which are then related to hypotheses about the human mind. Brown and Levinson's work, in contrast, takes its source data primarily from situated conversational exchanges, and generalizations are made with reference to empirically testable universals of discourse and interaction. By so doing, while using new kinds of data, they are also able to draw on and integrate a long tradition of research in social anthropology, conversational discourse analysis, and in syntax and linguistic pragmatics.

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The new introduction, which takes the form of a critical examination of the 1978 work in the context of research since then, explores these and related issues of theory. It brings together the recent theoretical work on inference in conversation, and discusses work by anthropologists, psychologists and linguists of various persuasions who have attempted to use or test the Brown and Levinson principles. In addition, it surveys the implications of their approach for a number of issues such as those of power and control, first and second language learning, conversation analysis and ritual, which are basic to interactional sociolinguistics. Although intended specifically for this volume, this introduction in itself is both a good guide to current directions in sociolinguistics and linguistic pragmatics and an argument for the important role sociolinguistics can play in illuminating the bases of social life.